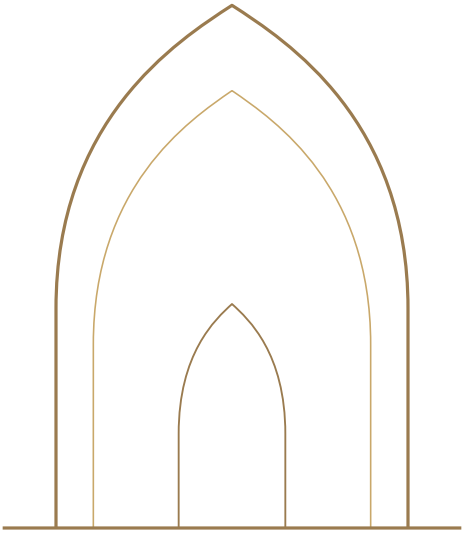

NINE DAYS OF PRAYER, BESIDE THE SONG

The Nine Day Prayer Companion

One page a day, one name, and the song at the heart of it.

SANCTORIA

How to pray these nine days

This is nine days of prayer to keep beside the prayer song. Each day asks for about ten minutes.

Choose a time that can be kept: the kitchen table before the house wakes, or the bedside at night. Read the verse and the short reflection. Pray the prayer, and at the ruled line say or write the name of the one you are praying for. If the song is for your own heart, the name is your own. If the one you are praying for has died, pray it for that soul.

Then play the song. It is the heart of each day, because it holds the name and the prayer together. Close with the prayers named at the foot of the page.

If a day is missed, nothing is lost. Pick it up again where it was left.

DAY 1 OF 9

Called By Name

Fear not, for I have redeemed thee, and called thee by thy name: thou art mine.

ISAIAS 43:1

Before this name was ever written down or sung in a chorus, God knew it. He knew it before anyone spoke it aloud at the font. So these nine days do not begin by telling Him something new. They begin by standing before Him and saying the name He already holds, slowly, the way it deserves to be said.

> *Lord, You call each of us by name, and You do not forget one. Today I bring before You _____, this child of Yours, whom You have known from the beginning. I do not come with many words. I come with one name. Receive it, Lord, and receive my prayer with it, for these nine days and beyond them. Amen.*

Play the song once and listen for the name. Then pray one Our Father, one Hail Mary and one Glory Be.

DAY 2 OF 9

Leaning On Him

Have confidence in the Lord with all thy heart, and lean not upon thy own prudence.

PROVERBS 3:5

Most of us pray with one hand open and the other still holding on. We bring a name to God and then go on carrying it alone in the small hours. Trust is not pretending to feel calm. It is handing over what was never ours to carry by ourselves, and doing it again tomorrow when we find we have picked it back up.

> *Father, I have carried this name a long way by myself. Today I place _____ in Your hands, which are larger and gentler than mine. Where I cannot see the way, let me trust that You can. Where I want to manage everything, teach me to lean on You. Give me the faith to leave it with You. Amen.*

Play the song once. Then pray one Our Father, one Hail Mary and one Glory Be.

DAY 3 OF 9

Love That Stays

Beareth all things, believeth all things, hopeth all things, endureth all things.

1 CORINTHIANS 13:7

Saint Paul is describing charity, the love that comes from God. It is not a feeling that rises and falls with the day. It stays. To keep praying over one name, year after year, through good news and through silence, is one of the plainest ways that love bears and hopes and endures. Hardly anyone sees it. God does.

> *Lord Jesus, teach me to love as You love. Let me hold _____ before You patiently, without anxiety and without keeping count. When I am tired, let me love by praying. When I have no words left, let the song carry them. Make my heart a quiet place where this name is always welcome. Amen.*

Play the song once. Then pray one Our Father, one Hail Mary and one Glory Be.

DAY 4 OF 9

Do Not Grow Weary

But they that hope in the Lord shall renew their strength, they shall take wings as eagles, they shall run and not be weary, they shall walk and not faint.

ISAIAS 40:31

Prayer that goes on for a long time can feel like standing still. The prophet says otherwise. Those who hope in the Lord are given new strength, not because the waiting is short, but because He meets them in it. Today is the fourth day. Coming back to the page again is itself the hoping.

> *Lord, renew my strength today. I have prayed for _____ before, and I will pray again tomorrow. Keep me from growing weary, and from measuring You by what I can see. Let me keep this small appointment with You faithfully, one day at a time, and leave the rest to You. Amen.*

Play the song once. Then pray one Our Father, one Hail Mary and one Glory Be.

DAY 5 OF 9

His Peace

Peace I leave with you, my peace I give unto you: not as the world giveth, do I give unto you. Let not your heart be troubled, nor let it be afraid.

JOHN 14:27

Our Lord spoke these words on the night before He died, to friends who were about to be very afraid. The peace He gives is not the world's kind, which depends on everything going well. It is His own, and it can rest in a heart while the questions are still open.

> *Jesus, giver of peace, let Your peace rest on _____ today, and on every heart that carries this name. Quiet what is troubled in me. Where I am afraid, stay with me. I do not ask to understand everything. I ask only to be near You, and to leave this name in Your peace. Amen.*

Play the song once, and sit quietly for a minute after it ends. Then pray one Our Father, one Hail Mary and one Glory Be.

DAY 6 OF 9

Behold Thy Mother

After that, he saith to the disciple: Behold thy mother. And from that hour, the disciple took her to his own.

JOHN 19:27

From the cross, Our Lord gave His mother to the disciple, and the Church has long seen in that disciple every one of us. Mary knows what it is to stand close to someone she loves and be able to do nothing but stay. A name brought to her is never a burden. She carries it to her Son.

> *Mary, my Mother, I entrust _____ to your care today. You stood at the cross and did not leave. Stand with me now. Take this name into your prayers and carry it to your Son, who refuses you nothing that is good. Pray for us, holy Mother of God. Amen.*

Play the song once. Then pray one Our Father, three Hail Marys and one Glory Be.

DAY 7 OF 9

Into His Hands

Cast thy care upon the Lord, and he shall sustain thee: he shall not suffer the just to waver for ever.

PSALM 54:23

There is a prayer that asks, and a prayer that lets go. Both are needed. To cast a care upon the Lord is not to stop caring. It is to stop holding on as though everything depended on our own grip. Today the prayer is simple: Thy will be done, said slowly, and meant as far as we are able.

> *Father, I have told You what is in my heart. Now I give You _____ without conditions. You love this soul more than anyone on earth is able to. Whatever You will, let it be done, and give me the grace to accept it. Sustain me while I wait. I leave this care with You. Amen.*

Play the song once. Then pray one Our Father, slowly, one Hail Mary and one Glory Be.

DAY 8 OF 9

Hope Beyond Sorrow

And God shall wipe away all tears from their eyes: and death shall be no more, nor mourning, nor crying, nor sorrow shall be any more, for the former things are passed away.

APOCALYPSE 21:4

This is where God is leading His people. Scripture closes with God Himself drying their tears. We are not there yet, and faith does not ask us to pretend that we are. It asks us to hold on to His promise while we wait, and to go on praying for one another along the way.

> *Lord, You see every tear, mine and those I know nothing about. I place _____ within Your promise today. Have mercy on us. Keep us in Your grace, and bring us at the last to the place where nothing is lost and no one is missing. Until then, keep my hope alive. Amen.*

Play the song once. Then pray one Our Father, one Hail Mary and one Glory Be.

DAY 9 OF 9

Give Thanks

Give praise to the Lord, for he is good: for his mercy endureth for ever.

PSALM 117:1

The ninth day is for thanks. Not because everything has been settled, but because God is good and His mercy does not run out. Give thanks for the life of the one you have prayed for. Give thanks for nine days kept, even imperfectly. A prayer of thanks is never wasted, and it is a fitting way to finish.

> *Lord, I thank You for the life of _____, and for every day You have given. Thank You for hearing me these nine days. Your mercy endures for ever. I do not finish this prayer today. I only set the page down. Keep this name in Your heart always, and keep me faithful in praying it. Amen.*

Play the song once more. Then pray one Our Father, one Hail Mary and one Glory Be, and make the Sign of the Cross.

After the ninth day

The nine days are finished. The prayer is not.

The song is still there, on the same private page and wherever it was saved. Play it on an ordinary morning, on a hard one, on a feast day or an anniversary. Each time it plays, and someone listens and means it, the name is lifted to God again.

No prayer book can promise an outcome. It can only help the asking go on.

Begin the nine days again whenever there is need, for the same name or for another. And keep these pages where they will be found.